

Public Companies: Data Center Networking & Cabling

From copper and fiber connectors up through switches and long-haul optical transport

Context: As AI clusters scale from thousands to hundreds of thousands of accelerators, the bottleneck is shifting from chip performance to network bandwidth, latency, and power. The data center interconnect market alone is projected to grow from ~\$15.6B (2025) to ~\$37.4B by 2032, driven by the shift from copper to high-capacity coherent optics at 400G/800G/1.6T speeds.

1. Network Switches & Routers (Systems)

The boxes that move traffic within and between data centers -- the layer most visible to network architects.

Company	Ticker	Role	Recent Signal (2026)
Arista Networks	ANET	Leading high-performance switch maker for AI fabrics and cloud data centers	Launched next-gen 1.6 Terabit portfolio for AI fabrics (June 2026); new XPO transceiver form factor cuts switch rack footprint 75%
Cisco Systems	CSCO	Largest incumbent networking vendor; switches, routers, optical components	Active participant in new EBO (expanded beam optical) connectivity standard alongside AMD, Meta, Arista (2026)
Nokia	NOK	Optical networking and routing, bolstered by 2025 Infinera acquisition	Achieved record 1.2 Tbps DWDM single-wavelength transmission on an AI-supercomputer-linked network (2025)

2. Switching Silicon & Custom Networking ASICs

The chips inside the switches and NICs -- increasingly custom silicon designed directly for hyperscalers.

Company	Ticker	Role	Recent Signal (2026)
Broadcom	AVGO	Dominant switch silicon (Tomahawk/Jericho) and custom AI networking ASICs; also co-packaged optics	Unveiled 3rd-gen co-packaged optics at 200 Gbps/lane for AI-scale networks; named a top optical interconnect leader at OFC 2026
Marvell Technology	MRVL	Custom data-center silicon: optical interconnect chips, Ethernet switching, and accelerators built for hyperscalers	Core supplier of both networking and custom-compute silicon moving/processing data inside AI/cloud data centers

3. Optical Components, Transceivers & Connectivity Chips

The physical-layer chips and modules that turn electrical signals into light (and back) for high-speed links inside and between data centers.

Company	Ticker	Role	Recent Signal (2026)
Coherent Corp	COHR	Engineered optical materials, transceivers, lasers, and photonics across communications and data center markets	Named a top BNP Paribas AI infrastructure pick; one of the more diversified pure optical-networking plays
Lumentum Holdings	LITE	Optical components and modules for data center and telecom networks	Highlighted AI data center optical opportunity in recent 2026 updates alongside Ciena

Credo Technology	CRDO	High-speed connectivity: active electrical cables (AECs), SerDes chiplets, retimers, optical DSPs	Conditions signals between servers, switches, and accelerators; core beneficiary of the copper-to-optical transition inside racks
Astera Labs	ALAB	Connectivity chips (PCIe/CXL retimers) linking GPUs, memory, and storage inside AI servers	Core beneficiary of scale-up AI server architectures requiring high-speed, low-latency interconnect
Fabrinet	FN	Contract manufacturer for optical transceivers and complex optical/electro-mechanical products	Named a top BNP Paribas AI infrastructure/optical interconnect pick alongside Arista and Ciena

4. Optical Networking Systems & Data Center Interconnect (DCI)

Systems that carry high-capacity traffic between data centers over metro, long-haul, and submarine distances.

Company	Ticker	Role	Recent Signal (2026)
Ciena	CIEN	#1 globally in data center interconnect and total optical networking; also #1 in submarine networks	Q2 FY2026 revenue \$1.6B, up 40% YoY; cloud provider revenue up 70% YoY; new Hyper-Rail tech (32x density, 75% power savings) for hyperscaler AI training networks

5. Copper Cabling, Connectors & Fiber Infrastructure

The physical wiring layer -- copper direct-attach cables, connectors, and fiber optic cable manufacturing -- undergoing rapid consolidation in 2026.

Company	Ticker	Role	Recent Signal (2026)
Amphenol	APH	Major connector/interconnect maker across copper, fiber, and power connectivity	Closed \$10.5B acquisition of CommScope's Connectivity & Cable Solutions business (Jan 2026); IT datacom segment posted triple-digit organic growth; joined new EBO connector standard
TE Connectivity	TEL	High-density data and power connectivity for hyperscale systems	Net sales up 15% YoY in Q2 FY2026; positioned as Amphenol's chief rival in AI infrastructure connectivity
Corning	GLW	Leading optical fiber and fiber cable manufacturer	Announced multiyear partnership with Nvidia (May 2026) to expand US-based optical connectivity manufacturing; also partnered with Meta and Amazon
CommScope	COMM	Network cabling and infrastructure (post sale of Connectivity & Cable Solutions unit to Amphenol)	Refocusing strategy on wireless infrastructure and home networking after using CCS sale proceeds to reduce debt
Belden	BDC	Signal transmission solutions including data center copper and fiber cabling	Smaller-cap exposure to structured cabling demand growth in enterprise and data center markets

6. Long-Haul / Dark Fiber Network Operators

Companies that own or lease the physical fiber routes connecting data centers across cities and regions, distinct from the equipment riding on top of that fiber.

Company	Ticker	Role	Recent Signal (2026)
Lumen Technologies	LUMN	Long-haul fiber network operator repositioning around AI/hyperscaler connectivity demand	Signed multiple large fiber capacity deals with hyperscalers to connect data center campuses (2025-2026)

Note: much of the dark fiber/long-haul route ownership market (e.g. Zayo) is privately held following past take-private transactions -- this is a thinner public list than the other categories.

Categories Worth Adding

- **Co-Packaged Optics (CPO) specialists** — an emerging architecture that integrates optics directly into the switch package rather than as pluggable modules; Broadcom and TSMC (via COUPE, integrated into CoWoS) are leading, with startups like Ranovus and Ayar Labs (both private) also active.
- **Network Interface Cards (NICs) & DPUs** — Nvidia's Mellanox-derived ConnectX/BlueField lines and Spectrum-X Ethernet/Quantum InfiniBand dominate this layer; already covered under Nvidia in prior AI infrastructure lists, but worth a dedicated line if you want full NIC/DPU competitive coverage (e.g. AMD's Pensando).
- **Submarine Cable Systems** — a distinct sub-category of long-haul infrastructure connecting data centers across oceans; Ciena (above) is the market leader here, but dedicated submarine cable owners/operators are mostly telecom carriers or private consortiums rather than clean public pure-plays.

Generated July 10, 2026. This is a disjoint reference set, not a ranked or filtered list.